

Chapter 10

Catalan 4...dxc4

5...a6 and 6...♘c6

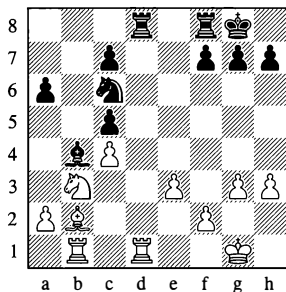
Variation Index

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.♙g2 a6 6.0-0 ♘c6

7.e3

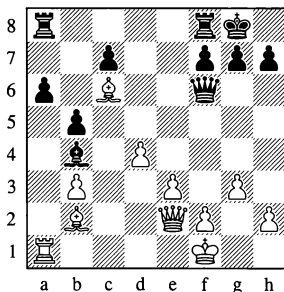
A) 7...♘d5	135
B) 7...♞b8 8.♘fd2	136
B1) 8...♞d7	136
B2) 8...e5 9.♙xc6† bxc6 10.dxe5 ♘g4 11.♘xc4 ♙e6 12.♘bd2	138
B21) 12...h5	139
B22) 12...♙b4	139
C) 7...♙d7 8.♞e2 b5 9.b3!? cxb3 10.axb3	140
C1) 10...♙b4	141
C2) 10...♙e7	141
C3) 10...♙d6 11.♙b2 0-0 12.♞c1	143
C31) 12...♘b4	144
C32) 12...♘d5	144

B2) note to 11...♙c6



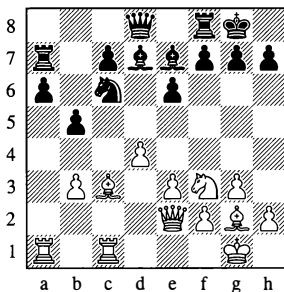
20.♙d5!N

C1) after 19...♞f6

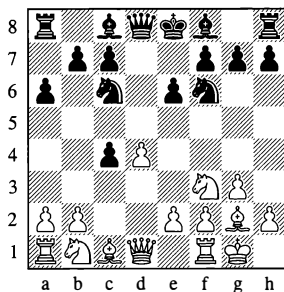


20.♞c2!N

C2) after 14...♞a7

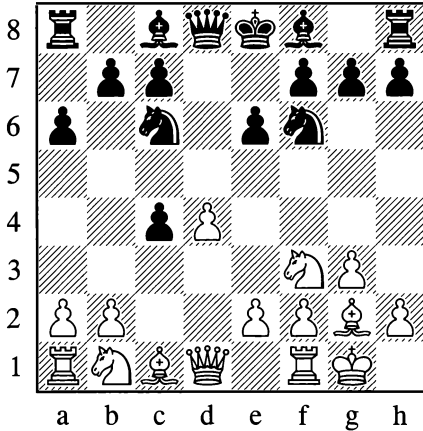


15.♘e1!N



1.d4 ♖f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♗f3 dxc4 5.♙g2
a6 6.0-0 ♗c6

This is an ambitious choice from Black. In most of the lines he will retain his extra pawn, but White has a few interesting ways to fight for the initiative.



7.e3

This is another significant change from *GM 1*, in which I recommended 7.♗c3 ♖b8 8.e4. There have been many developments in that line, and overall I am not completely satisfied with White's prospects. Here is one relevant example: 8...♙e7 9.♖e2 b5 10.♗d1 0-0 11.d5 exd5 12.e5 d4 13.exf6 ♙xf6 14.♖e4 ♙b7 15.♗d5 ♗b4! 16.♗xf6† ♖xf6 17.♖f4 c5! 18.♖xf6 gxf6 19.♙f4 ♖bc8 With highly unclear play, Caruana – Cheparinov, Villafranca de los Barros 2010.

Here Black has three main options:
A) 7...♗d5, B) 7...♖b8 and C) 7...♙d7.

7...♙d6?! is hardly a good idea, as after 8.♗bd2 ♗a5 White has the strong 9.♗e5!. In the event of 9...♙xe5, as in Yevseev – Khuseinkhodzhaev, Peterhof 2009, White can even try 10.♖a4†!N c6 11.dxe5 b5 12.♖c2 ♗d5 13.b3 ♙b7 14.♗e4 0-0 15.♙d2 with a serious advantage.

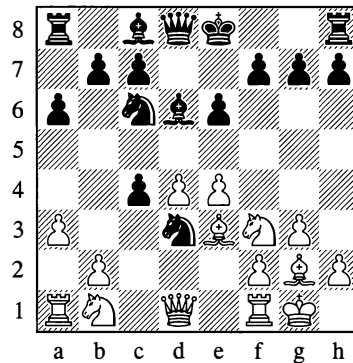
A) 7...♗d5

This move is not as bad as I suspected it might be when I first saw it. Black wants just to play ...♗b6 in order to keep his extra pawn.

8.e4 ♗b6

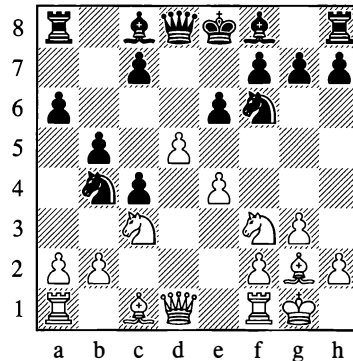
Other squares are much worse:

8...♗db4? 9.♙e3 ♙d6 10.a3 ♗d3 occurred in Weiler – Grzeca, Altenkirchen 2012, and now White could have obtained a huge advantage with:

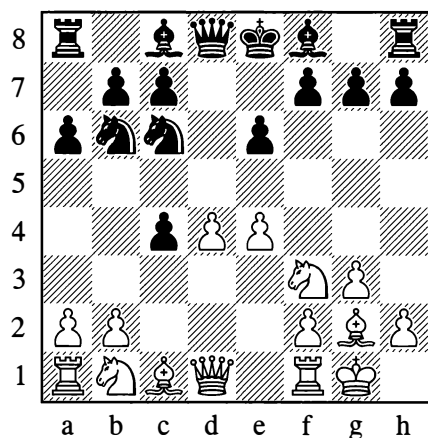


11.♖c2N b5 12.e5 ♙e7 13.b3! It is hard to suggest anything for Black. A possible continuation is 13...♗a5 14.bxc4 bxc4 15.♗fd2! ♖b8 16.♗xc4 ♗xc4 17.♖xc4 ♗b2 18.♖c2 and Black's knight is in big trouble.

8...♗f6 9.♗c3 b5 (Other moves allow White to regain the pawn, for example 9...♙e7 10.♖a4 ♙d7 11.♖xc4 0-0 12.♗d1 b5 13.♖e2 with a comfortable edge, Kachiani – Burtman, Azov 1990.) 10.d5 ♗b4



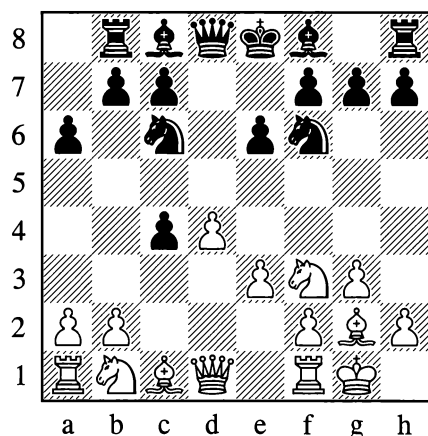
11.a4! Beneficially opening up the a-file. 11...exd5 (After 11...♖b8N 12.axb5 axb5 13.♙g5 ♙e7 14.♘d4 White's initiative plays itself.) Now in a couple of games White failed to find 12.axb5!N when Black is in serious trouble. For instance, 12...♙e7 13.e5 ♘e4 14.♘d4! ♙b7 15.♙f5→ with an almost decisive initiative.



9.♙e3 ♙e7 10.♖e2 0-0 11.♘c3 ♙e8 12.a3 ♙d7 13.♖ad1

White has promising compensation for the pawn, Kireev – Kruk, corr. 2012.

B) 7...♖b8



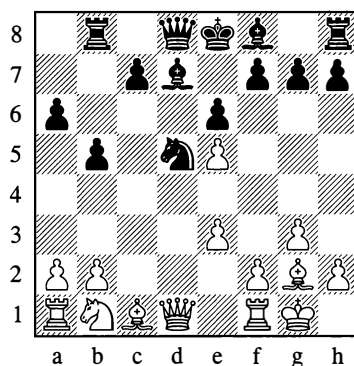
This is the first of Black's more challenging alternatives.

8.♘fd2

8.♖e2 b5 9.b3 cxb3 10.axb3 is an interesting alternative, but it gives Black a better version of variation C below, since his light-squared bishop can be developed comfortably to b7.

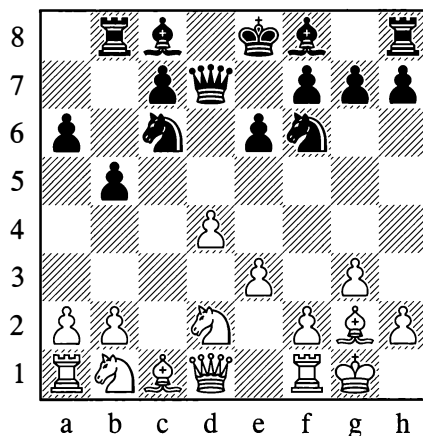
Here the two main options are **B1) 8...♖d7** and **B2) 8...e5**.

8...♙d7 9.♘xc4 b5 works out well for White after 10.♙e5! ♘xe5 11.dxe5 ♘d5 as in Le Quang – Ponkratov, Moscow 2013. Here White should just continue with normal development as follows:



12.♘d2N ♙e7 13.b3 0-0 14.♙e4 White has good chances to seize the initiative on the kingside, for instance 14...c5 15.♙b2 c4 16.♖g4 g6 17.♖fd1 and Black's dark squares look rather vulnerable.

B1) 8...♖d7 9.♘xc4 b5 10.♘cd2



10...♙b7

10...e5 11.♟b3 ♙d6 was a less challenging alternative seen in Gorelov – Kharitonov, Volgodonsk 1981. At this point 12.dxe5N ♟xe5 13.e4 ♟c4 14.♚c2 0–0 15.♟1d2± would have given White a comfortable advantage.

11.♟b3N

I like this idea more than 11.a4 and 11.♟c3 as played previously. The knight establishes control over the c5-square and prepares e3–e4 and ♙e3.

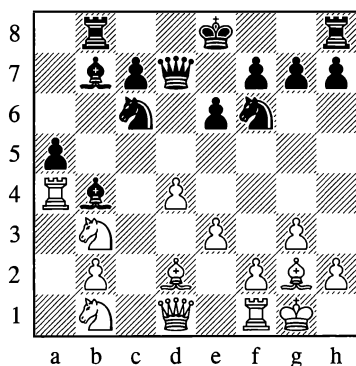
11...♟d8

This has been Black's choice in games featuring the other moves mentioned above, but it does not work so well here. I also considered:

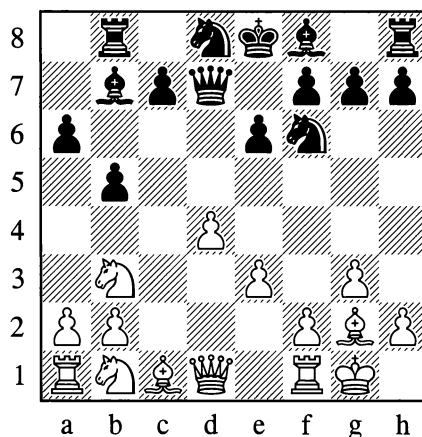
11...e5 proves to be premature after 12.d5 ♟d8 13.e4 c6 14.♙g5, when Black is not ready for such a tense clash in the centre, since his king is still uncastled.

11...♙d6 also does not work well after 12.e4 e5 13.dxe5 ♙xe5 14.♟c5! ♚xd1 15.♙xd1 ♙c8 16.♟c3 0–0 17.♙e3 with an unpleasant endgame for Black.

Finally, 11...a5 runs into 12.a4! bxa4 13.♙xa4 ♙b4 14.♙d2 when the a5-pawn is a clear target. The continuation might be:



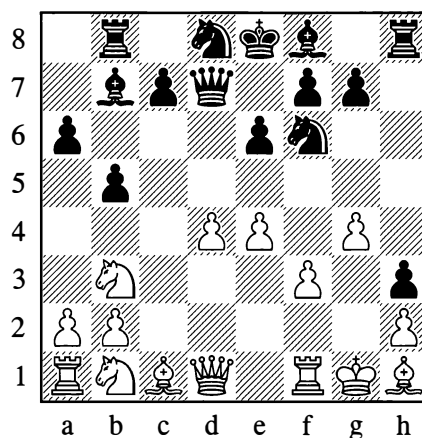
14...♟d8 15.♟xa5 ♙xa5 16.♙xa5 ♙xg2 17.♟xg2 ♙xb2 18.♚c1 ♙b8 19.♚a3 Despite the simplifications, Black is a long way from solving his problems.

**12.f3!**

There will be no bishop trade! I don't see what Black can do to oppose White's simple plan of expanding in the centre.

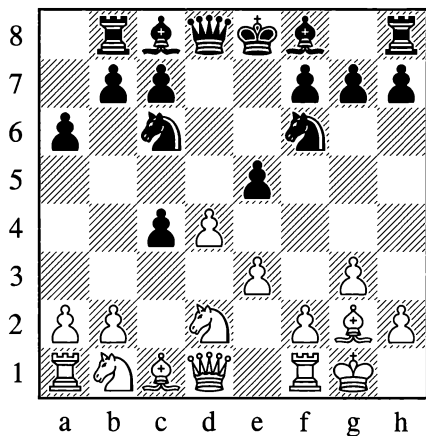
12...h5

My engine recommends this advance, but I don't see what Black accomplishes after the 'human' reply:

13.e4 h4 14.g4 h3 15.♙h1

White dominates the centre and his light-squared bishop will get back into the game easily enough, while the h3-pawn is a long-term target.

B2) 8...e5



Definitely the most ambitious option. White has no real choice but to accept the challenge.

9.♙xc6† bxc6 10.dxe5 ♘g4 11.♘xc4 ♙e6

Other options are clearly worse:

11...♙d5? 12.b3 ♙e6 13.f4 ♙h6 14.♙e2 ♙c5 15.♙a3± Zaichik – Anikaev, Telavi 1982.

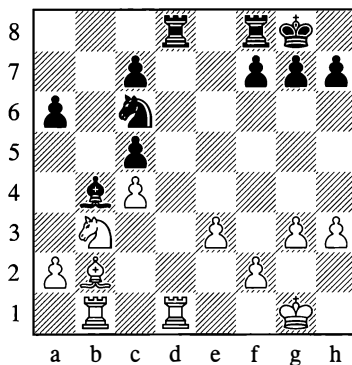
11...♙xd1 12.♙xd1 ♙e6 13.♘bd2 ♙d8 14.b3
White maintains a comfortable edge in the endgame, for instance:

14...♙xc4 15.bxc4 ♙b4 16.♙b1 c5

Another game continued 16...♙a5 17.♔f1! 0-0 (17...♘h2† 18.♔e2 ♘g4 19.♙b7 ♙xd2 20.♙xd2 0-0 21.f4±) 18.♔e2 ♙xd2 19.♙xd2 ♘xe5 20.♙e1!? with a nice edge for White, Lissang – Welin, Sweden 2007.

17.h3 ♘xe5 18.♙b2 ♘c6 19.♘b3 0-0

Now in Kunte – Istratescu, Montreal 2008, White could have secured a clear plus with:



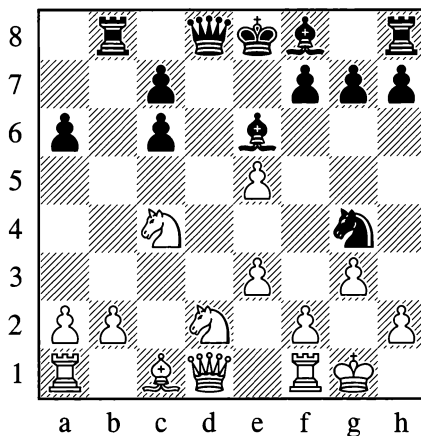
20.♙d5!N ♙xd5 21.cxd5 ♘e7 22.♙c1 ♘xd5 23.♘xc5

Black is destined to suffer with his queenside weaknesses.

12.♘bd2

From this position Black's two main ideas are **B21) 12...h5** and **B22) 12...♙b4**.

12...♙d5 13.b3 h5 was Carlhammar – Schneider, Helsingborg 1991. Now I believe White could have simply played 14.h3N ♘xe5 (14...h4 fails to work due to 15.hxg4 hxg3 16.♙f3 ♙xg4 17.♙g2!±) 15.e4 ♙c5 16.♙a3 ♙b5 17.♙xf8 ♔xf8 18.♘xe5 ♙xe5 19.♔g2 ♙d8 20.♙e2 ♙b2 21.♙fd1± with a clear positional advantage.

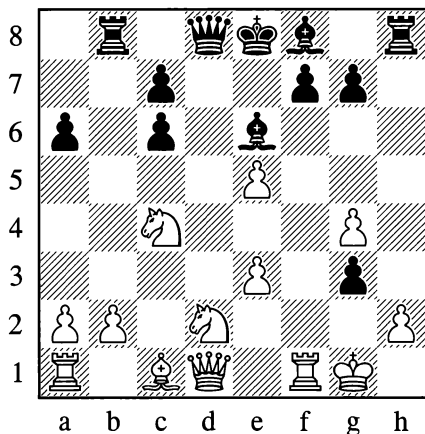


B21) 12...h5 13.f3!

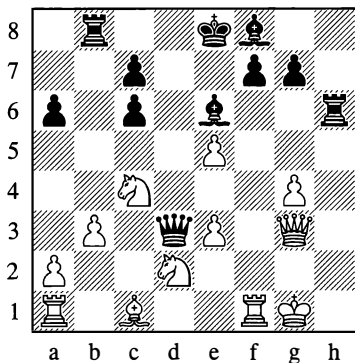
White needs to be accurate. I went wrong with 13.h3, and after 13...h4! 14.hxg4 hxg3 15.fxg3 ♖d3! Black obtained a dangerous attack in Avrukh – A. Mikhalevski, Israel 2010.

13...h4

13...♘h6? 14.♖c2 ♖d5 15.b3 leaves Black clearly worse.

14.fxg4 hxg3**15.♖f3! gxh2+♞**

This seems like a better try than 15...♖d3 16.b3 ♖xh2 17.♖xg3 ♖h6 as played in Postny – A. Mikhalevski, Israel 2009.

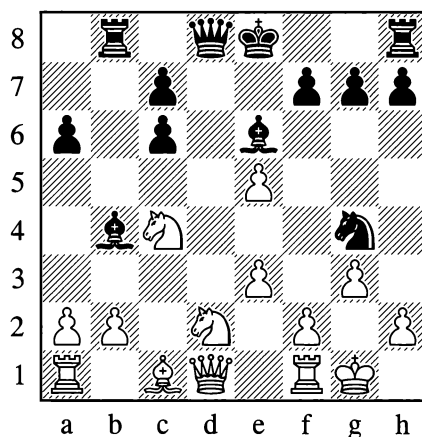


Here the most convincing way to deal with the ...♗xg4 threat would have been

18.♖f4! ♞d5 19.♖f3!, intending to complete development with ♗b2 and ♖af1, when Black does not have much to show for his material deficit.

16.♖h1 ♖d7 17.b3 ♗xg4 18.♖g3 ♗e6 19.♗b2±

Black hardly has any dangerous ideas.

B22) 12...♗b4**13.♖c2!?♞**

I propose this new move as an improvement over 13.♖e2, when 13...h5 was double-edged in M. Muzychuk – Kosteniuk, Warsaw 2013.

13...h5

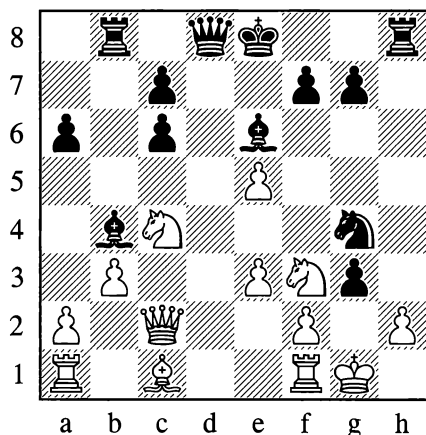
This is Black's principal idea in these positions.

13...♗xd2 is no problem for White after the accurate: 14.♗xd2! ♗xc4 15.♖xc4 ♘xe5 16.♖f4 ♖d5 17.♗c3 ♘f3+ 18.♖h1 0-0 19.♖ad1 ♖h5 20.h4±

14.b3 h4!

Of course not 14...♗xd2? 15.♘xd2 h4 16.♘f3 hxg3 17.hxg3 with a big advantage for White.

15.♘f3 hxg3



16.fxc3!

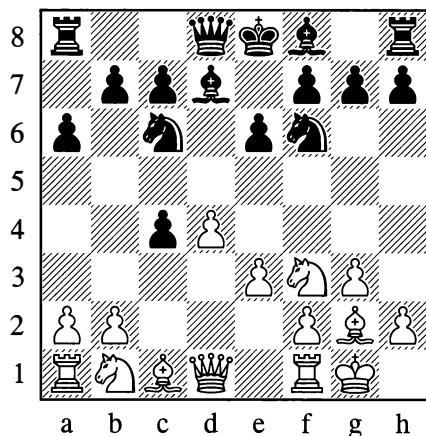
Obviously we should avoid 16.hxg3? ♖d7, when the open h-file is a source of great concern.

This critical position requires further investigation and testing. I like White's chances, and will present one illustrative line:

16...♞d5 17.♙b2 ♙c5 18.♞ad1 ♙xe3†
19.♜xe3 ♜xe3 20.♞xd5 ♜xc2 21.♞d2 ♜b4
22.♜d4

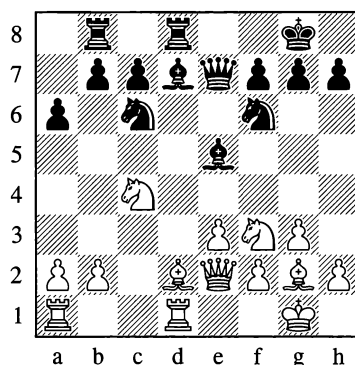
White is obviously better and can continue playing without much risk.

C) 7...♙d7



8.♞e2 b5

In a number of recent games Black has tried 8...♙d6 9.♞xc4 0–0, returning the pawn and aiming for a quick strike in the centre. I suggest following Gelfand's example: 10.♞d1 ♞b8 11.♜bd2 e5 12.dxe5 ♙xe5 (Apparently Black was not satisfied with 12...♜xe5 13.♜xe5 ♙xe5 14.♜f3 ♙d6 15.e4, when White indeed has good prospects.) 13.♞e2 ♞e7 14.♜c4 ♞fd8 15.♙d2



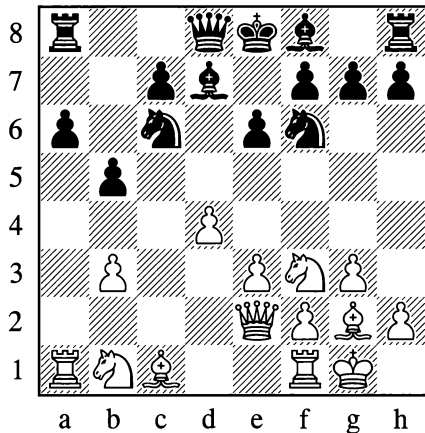
15...♙d4!?. This was an interesting try for Black in Gelfand – Wang Hao, Tashkent 2012. Perhaps Boris got confused by Black's last move, as the direct 16.♜xd4N ♜xd4 17.♞f1 ♜c6 18.♙c3! ♜e4 19.♙e1± would have reached a position where Black can hardly claim to have sufficient compensation for White's bishop pair.

9.b3!?

This strategic pawn sacrifice greatly appeals to me.

9...cxb3 10.axb3

We have reached the main tabiya for the 7...♙d7 variation. Unlike the previous lines, White has made no real effort to regain the c4-pawn, instead simply exchanging it in order to open the a- and c-files and expose Black's structural weaknesses, leading to long-term positional compensation.



Black has three sensible developing moves:
C1) 10...♖b4, C2) 10...♖e7 and C3) 10...♖d6.

C1) 10...♖b4

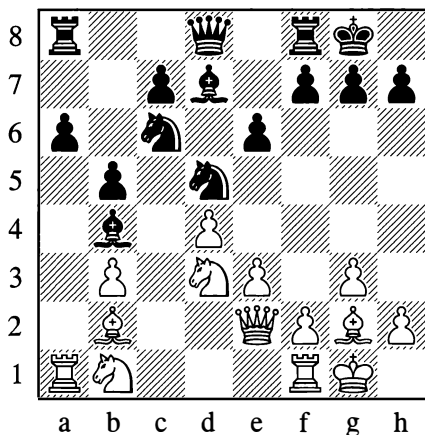
This gives White an opportunity to carry out a strong manoeuvre.

11.♖e5! ♖d5

The exchange sacrifice does not work:
11...♖xe5?N 12.♖xa8 ♖xa8 13.dxe5 ♖e4
14.f3 ♖c5 15.♖c2+

12.♖d3 0-0 13.♖b2

This move has only been played in correspondence games, but it is undoubtedly the most logical choice. The following game gives a good illustration of how play may proceed.



13...♖e7 14.♖c3 ♖cb4 15.♖xb4 ♖xb4
16.♖xd5

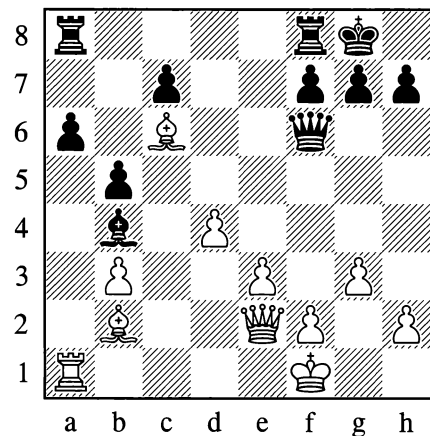
White accepts the challenge.

16...exd5 17.♖xd5 ♖h3 18.♖c6!

A fresh positional sacrifice.

18...♖xf1 19.♖xf1 ♖f6

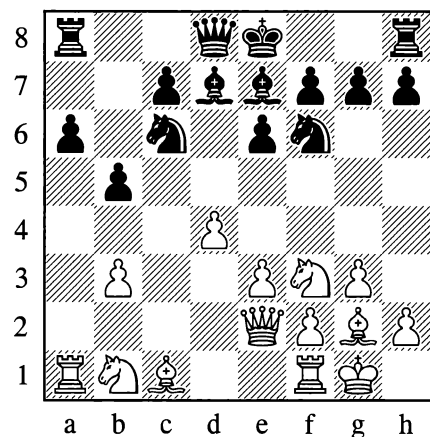
Now in Schiller – Wharrier, email 2012, White rushed to take on a8. A stronger and more thematic option would have been:



20.♖c2!N

White has superb compensation; his light-squared bishop is more valuable than the black rook.

C2) 10...♖e7



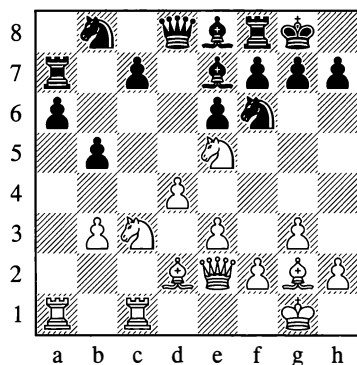
This is not the most active choice, but Black is hoping to keep things solid.

11.♙d2!?

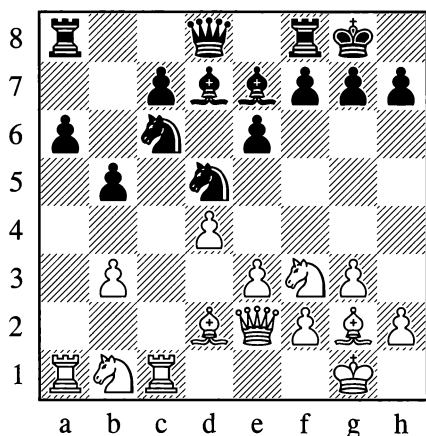
Somehow this move appeals to me the most, despite the fact that 11.♙b2 and 11.♙c3 are more popular.

11...0-0 12.♞c1 ♘d5

I would also like to mention: 12...♞a7 13.♙c3 ♘b8 (I also checked 13...♙e8!?N, which looks better than the text move. Nevertheless, after 14.♙e1! ♘b4 15.♙a2! ♙xa2 16.♞xa2 ♘d5 17.♙d3 White has excellent compensation.) 14.♙e5 ♙e8



15.♙a2! Intending ♘b4 – a strong manoeuvre which is worth remembering. 15...♙d5 16.♞e1!? ♙d6 17.♙d3 White was clearly better in D. Berczes – Goloshchapov, Griesheim 2011.



13.♙c3 ♙xc3

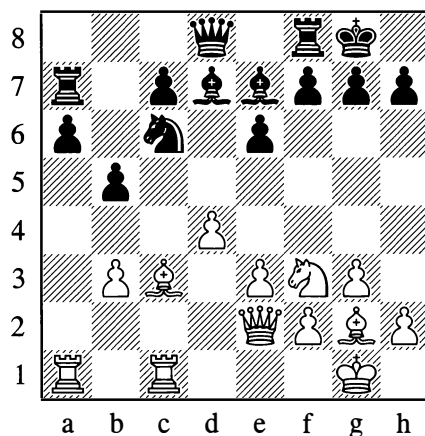
Other moves are hardly satisfactory for Black. For instance, both 13...♙db4 14.♙e4 f6 15.♙e1 and 13...♞c8 14.♙e1 ♙db4 15.♙e4 give White clearly better play.

14.♙xc3

This is better than 14.♞xc3?! ♞a7 15.♞c2 a5 16.♙e1 ♙b4 17.♙xb4 ♙xb4 18.♙d3 ♙d6 when Black was fine in Arun Prasad – Arnold, Paris 2011.

14...♞a7

This position first occurred in Kachiani Gersinka – Ar. Petrosian, Dortmund 2000, and it has since been repeated numerous times.



15.♙e1!N

I find it strange that nobody has played this logical move yet.

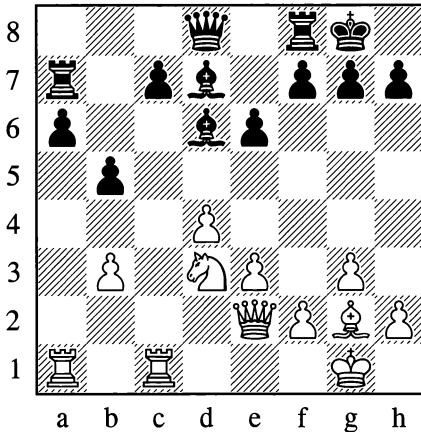
15...♙b4

I also analysed: 15...a5 16.♞xb5! It is best to accept the challenge. 16...♙xd4 17.♞c4 ♙b5 The only move. 18.♞xa5 ♞xa5 19.♙xa5 Despite the simplifications, White maintains definite pressure, as shown after 19...♙d6 20.♙d3 ♞e7 21.♙b4!.

16.♙xb4 ♙xb4 17.♙d3 ♙d6

17...♞e7 does not change the character of

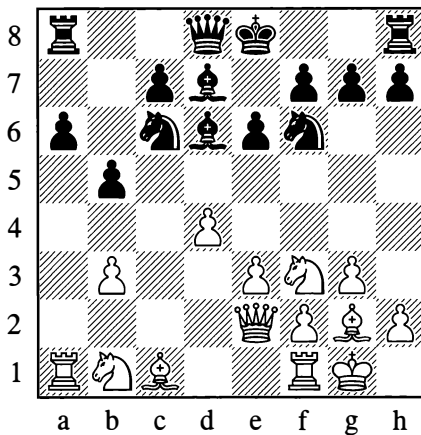
the game after 18.♙c2 ♜c8 19.♙c6! with good positional compensation.



18.b4 ♙e7 19.♙b2

White has great compensation for the missing pawn.

C3) 10...♙d6



This has been the most popular choice. The bishop is more active here than on e7, but less exposed than on b4.

11.♙b2 0–0

11...♙e7?!

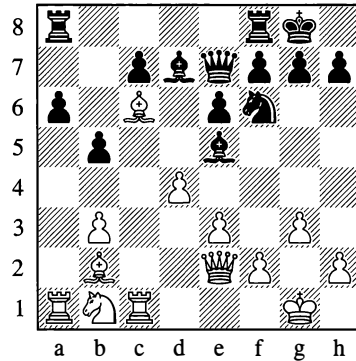
This has been played a few times, but it allows White to develop a quick initiative.

12.♙c1 0–0

12...♙a7? 13.♖e5! is already winning, and after 13...♙xe5 14.dxe5 ♖d5 15.♖c3 ♖cb4 16.♖xd5 ♖xd5 17.♙d4 ♙a8 18.e4 ♖b6 19.♙xc7 Black was in a hopeless situation in Gupta – Stockmann, Bad Wiessee 2013.

13.♖e5! ♙xe5 14.♙xc6!?

14.dxe5N ♖d5 15.♖c3 is also great for White.

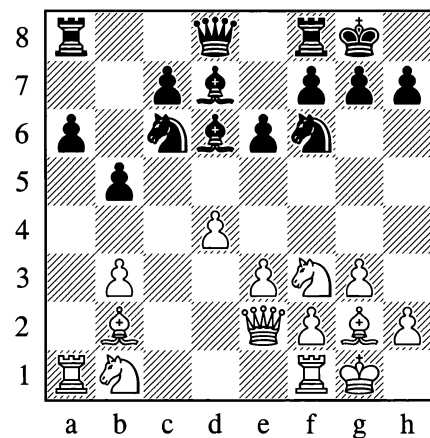


14...♙d6 15.♙xa8 ♙xa8 16.♖d2 e5 17.dxe5 ♙xe5

Somehow White went on to lose from this position in Evdokimov – Shinkevich, Ufa 2004. The simplest way to maintain a clear advantage would have been:

18.♙xe5N ♙xe5 19.e4±

Intending ♙e3 and f2-f3. Black clearly does not have enough for the exchange.



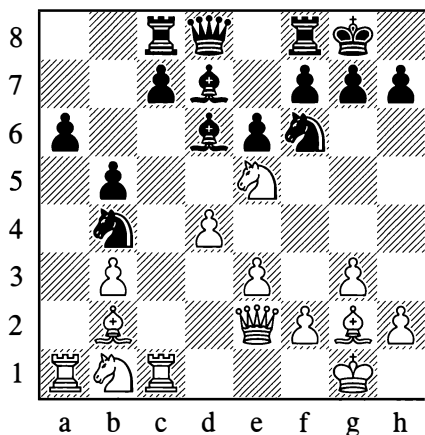
12.♖c1

Here we will consider **C31) 12...♟b4** followed by the more popular **C32) 12...♟d5**.

C31) 12...♟b4 13.♞e5 ♖c8

13...♞fd5? is no good in view of 14.♞xd7 ♖xd7 15.e4 ♟b6 16.e5 ♞e7 17.♞xa8 ♖xa8 18.♞d2± when Black does not have enough for the exchange.

13...♞a7 is playable, but 14.♞a3 ♞e8 15.e4 gave White great compensation in Bucek – Hnatovsky, Internet 2011.

**14.♞a3!?**

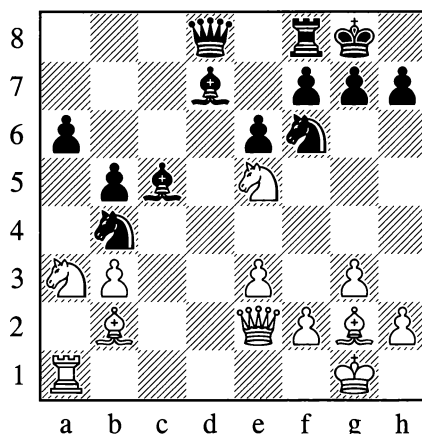
I like this, although 14.♞d2 ♖e7 15.♞d3 ♖fd8 also looked dangerous for Black in Zilka – Navara, Czech Republic 2009. A logical continuation is: 16.♞xb4N ♞xb4 17.♞xa6 c5 18.dxc5 ♖xc5 19.♖xc5 ♞xc5 20.♞xf6 ♖xf6 (20...gxf6?! 21.♞e4 is riskier for Black.) 21.♞e4 ♖e7 22.♞xc5 ♖xc5 23.♖d3 ♖c7 24.♞d6 ♟f8± Black should be able to hold, although White can certainly keep playing for a while without risk.

14...c5N

This seems like a logical attempt to improve on 14...♞xe5 15.dxe5 ♞fd5 16.♞d4, when White had great compensation in Fortune – Weiss, email 2011.

15.dxc5 ♖xc5

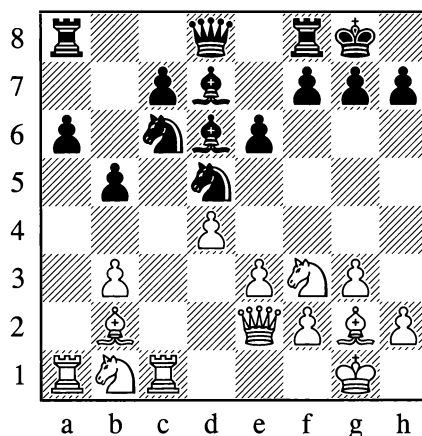
In the event of 15...♞xc5 16.♞c2 a5 17.♞a3 ♖b6 18.♞xd7 ♞xd7 19.♞xb5± White maintains a pleasant edge, thanks to the bishop pair.

16.♖xc5 ♞xc5**17.♞c2! ♞xc2 18.♖xc2 ♖b6 19.♞d3 ♞e7**

Also after 19...♞d6 20.♞d4 ♖b8 21.♖xa6 Black is under considerable pressure.

20.♞d4 ♖d6 21.♞c5 ♖c7 22.♖xa6±

White has regained the pawn, and can continue pressing with no risk.

C32) 12...♟d5

This is by far the most popular move in the position, although most of the games are from correspondence/email play. Most of the ideas are the same as in the previous lines, and White does not have to do anything fancy to maintain his compensation.

13.♖c3

White does not mind exchanging pieces, as the removal of the d5-knight will help to increase the pressure on the long diagonal.

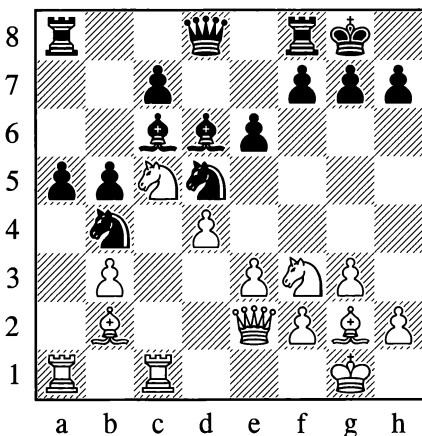
13...♖cb4

13...♖xc3?!N is too compliant, and after 14.♙xc3 White's initiative is quite potent. A sample line is: 14...♖e7 15.♖e5 ♖d5 16.♙a5 ♙e8 17.♖d3 f5 18.♙c2 White has typical compensation, with an even better version than in some of the other lines given.

13...♙e7 14.♖e4 The knight is heading for c5. 14...a5 15.♖e5 ♖cb4 White has several interesting ideas here, but I prefer 16.♖c5 ♙xe5 17.dxe5 with rich compensation, as in Foulds – Coyne, corr. 2014. White's pieces are perfectly placed, and he has good chances to seize the initiative on the kingside.

14.♖e4 a5 15.♖c5 ♙c6

15...♙xc5 is well met by 16.dxc5!♙, opening a path for the dark-squared bishop, as in Tinjaca Ramirez – Sheretyuk, corr. 2013.



16.♖e5 ♙xe5 17.dxe5

Again White's compensation was obvious in Oppitz – Hirr, Internet 2011.

Conclusion

5...a6 6.0–0 ♖c6 is a challenging system, which is generally played with the intention of holding on to the c4-pawn. I recommend departing from *GM 1* with 7.e3, when Black has two main options.

7...♙b8 leads to dynamic play after 8.♖fd2 e5 9.♙xc6† bxc6 10.dxe5 ♖g4 11.♖xc4 ♙e6 12.♖bd2, when White has gone from being a pawn down to a pawn up, but has been forced to part with his important 'Catalan bishop'. Black has some attacking prospects with ...h5-h4, but my analysis indicates that White can keep control and steer the game towards favourable simplifications.

7...♙d7 8.♙e2 b5 sees Black firmly protecting his extra pawn on c4, so I like the straightforward plan of swapping it off with 9.b3!? cxb3 10.axb3. White has long-term positional compensation and the black bishop is misplaced on d7. We analysed three moves for Black but, although some of the finer details vary from one line to the next, the general ideas remain similar. In all cases, White gets a lasting initiative with natural, easy-to-understand moves.